



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Great Hearts Northern Oaks

School Website: <https://northernnoaks.greatheartsamerica.org/>

December 21, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Great Hearts Northern Oaks (GHNO) demonstrates a clearly classical orientation consistent with the Six Essential Elements framework. Across most categories, GHNO's public materials reveal strong commitments to liberal arts formation, truth-forming aims, Great Books and a classical curriculum, Socratic pedagogy, a teacher-led "living curriculum," and deep parent/community partnership. The school explicitly centers education on the pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty, and presents a curriculum built around classical liberal arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric), Latin study, and engagement with great books and Western tradition. Public materials repeatedly emphasize formation of character, memory and virtue, and communal life rooted in a shared classical ethos. The aggregate assessment is CLASSICAL.

- **Element 1 (Religious and Metaphysical Foundations):** Somewhat Classical. The school foregrounds transcendental ideals (truth, goodness, beauty) and virtue, but there is less explicit documentation of theology, liturgical practice, or liturgical/calendar-centered worship within GHNO's public-facing content. Evidence includes explicit references to transcendentals and virtue, and explicit statements about truth, goodness, and beauty as real ideals, alongside the school's philosophical realism about knowledge. Positive indicators outweigh explicit theology signals, but liturgical/theological practices are not strongly documented in the public materials analyzed. See Evidence and keyword analysis below.
□filecite□turn4file0□turn7file0□
- **Element 2 (Purpose and Goal):** CLASSICAL. The GHNO mission centers formation of virtue and wisdom through a liberal-arts education aimed at truth, goodness, and beauty, with explicit emphasis on character formation and the cultivation of human excellence. The materials present formation over information, and a telos oriented toward the true, good, and beautiful. Evidence includes "The mission of GHNO is to cultivate the minds and hearts of students through the pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty" and language about liberal education and formation. Positive keywords (formation, liberal education, pursuit of the true/good/beautiful) are clearly present; negligible negative signals observed.
□filecite□turn5file0□turn7file0□
- **Element 3 (Curriculum):** CLASSICAL. The public materials consistently reference seven liberal arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and a historically grounded curriculum, with explicit Latin study, Western-tradition content, and Great Books engagement. The Upper School emphasizes in-depth Latin, seven years of math/science, and study of Aristotle and Dostoyevsky; the Academy graduate description cites grammar, rhetoric, logic, history, natural science, and philosophy, plus exposure to the arts. Positive indicators (Great Books/Great Conversation, Trivium/Quadrivium, Latin, Western tradition) are strong; no substantial evidence of modern-only, non-classical substitutes. See evidence citations.
□filecite□turn0file0□turn4file0□
- **Element 4 (Pedagogy):** CLASSICAL. Pedagogical approaches include Socratic discussion and seminars, memory/recitation traditions in lower grades, and rhetoric-focused upper-level opportunities. Evidence includes explicit references to the Socratic method guiding learning, opportunities for seminars/rhetoric, and the presence of a musical/chant-like memory culture in lower grades. The presence of contemplative/restful elements (Scholé-like aspects) is present in some GHNO materials, though not exhaustively mapped. Overall, the pedagogy aligns with classic methods

(Socratic inquiry, rhetoric, memory work) rather than a solely project-based/constructivist approach. [filecite\turn7file0\turn6file1\turn7file11](#)

- Element 5 (Faculty): CLASSICAL. The faculty is portrayed as a core, virtuous living curriculum with model teachers and mentors, and formal roles (Headmaster, Dean of Teachers, Dean of Academics, directors). The “portrait of a teacher,” “living curriculum,” and emphasis on character and professional development are present. Leadership structures and faculty development language are evident in the School’s materials. Positive keyword signals (model teachers, living curriculum, mentors) are observable; few counter-indications are evident in the public materials. [filecite\turn0file6\turn7file7](#)
- Element 6 (Parents & Community): CLASSICAL. GHNO emphasizes parent partnership, co-teaching, parent formation, and an active Parent Service Organization (PSO), along with extensive family resources, volunteer opportunities, and community engagement. The Family Handbook language, PSO, and “Time, Talent, and Treasure” prompts, plus parent visits and open campus language, strongly support a classical-parent-partnership model. Evidence includes explicit calls for parent involvement, governance, and ongoing family engagement. [filecite\turn7file4\turn7file5](#)

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Transcendentals in GHNO language: “the transcendentals, namely the good, the true, and the beautiful.”
 - The mission statement emphasizes pursuing truth, goodness, and beauty.
 - Philosophy of knowledge and virtue: “We are not romantics, but philosophical realists who believe the world is knowable, that truth is worth seeking, and that strong character is built through rigor and the cultivation of good habits of mind and body.”
 - Socratic method and wonder in learning contribute to a metaphysical/epistemological framing of learning.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords observed: truth, goodness, beauty, transcendentals, virtue. (Multiple explicit instances across mission and curriculum statements.) [filecite\turn7file0\turn7file1](#)
 - Negative keywords observed: minimal to none in public materials (no explicit secular relativism signals). The public materials emphasize objective/transcendent aims rather than relativism.
- Why this rating
 - The school foregrounds transcendentals and virtue, and explicitly connects education to the real/-knowable truth, goodness, and beauty. However, explicit theology, liturgical practices, or chapel-worship signals are not robustly documented in the public site materials. Thus, it is strongly classical in foundation, but with some religious-metaphysical cues not as clearly documented on-site. CLASSIFICATION: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Mission centers formation of virtue and wisdom through pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty.
 - Emphasis on liberal education and formation (paideia) and the telos of pursuing truth/beauty/-goodness.
 - Rejection of formation-as-information emphasis in favor of character and human flourishing. Public materials emphasize formation rather than mere information transfer.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords observed: formation, liberal education, pursuit of the true/good/beautiful, telos, great conversation, moral imagination, human flourishing.
 - Negative keywords observed: minimal to none; no strong signals of workforce-readiness language within the GHNO public materials.
- Why this rating
 - GHNO presents a clear classical purpose: formation, virtue, wisdom, and a telos oriented toward

truth/goodness/beauty embedded in a liberal-arts framework. The public content aligns with core classical aims more than any non-classical shift. CLASSICAL.

Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Liberal arts foundation: grammar, rhetoric, logic; history; natural science; philosophy; artistic disciplines.
 - Upper School focus: Latin in depth; seven years of math and science; study of Aristotle and Dostoyevsky; senior thesis.
 - Great Books / Great Conversation orientation; Western tradition; broad engagement with authoritative texts.
 - Graduation description: Great Hearts' emphasis on the liberal-arts core curriculum in the Western tradition and living-books approach.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords observed: Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric); Great Books; Great Conversation; Latin; Western tradition; history, philosophy; quadrivium/trivium references manifest in public content.
 - Negative keywords observed: negligible; no strong evidence of a non-classical, project-based-only curriculum in the public site.
- Why this rating
 - The curriculum is explicitly classical: Trivium/Quadrivium concepts, Latin, Great Books, Western-civilization focus, and a senior-thesis capstone. CLASSICAL.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Socratic method used to guide learning; emphasis on wonder and depth of inquiry.
 - Upper-school pedagogy includes seminars, rhetoric training, and opportunities to give speeches. Public materials describe rhetoric and oration/goals.
 - Lower-school practices include memory work, recitation, and chants within a “memory/chant” tradition; Athenaeum after-school program ties to classical culture.
 - Restful/Scholé notions are present (e.g., discussions of quiet reflection and contemplation in the pedagogy discussions and related literature).
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords observed: Socratic method, seminars, rhetoric, memory/recitation, wonder, scholé/restful learning, liturgical learning context (where discussed in related materials). [file0turn7file7](#)
 - Negative keywords observed: not commonly present in GHNO public content; no pervasive anti-classical pedagogy signals found.
- Why this rating
 - The pedagogy aligns with classical norms (Socratic dialogue, seminars, rhetoric, memory work, contemplation). CLASSICAL.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Headmaster, Deans of Teachers/Academics, and other administrative leaders described as models of learning and character; teachers serve as living curriculum.
 - The public materials emphasize teachers as “models of learning and character” and the faculty as a core part of the Academy culture.
 - The administration page describes leadership roles and faculty development; the “portrait of a teacher” and “faculty as friends” notions appear in the classical lexicon.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords observed: model teachers, living curriculum, portrait of a teacher, faculty of friends, mentorship, character formation.

- Negative keywords observed: limited evidence of non-classical faculty signals; no explicit counter indicators in public materials.
- Why this rating
 - GHNO presents a strong living-curriculum, mentor-teacher model with explicit faculty leadership structures and character formation emphasis. CLASSICAL.

Element 6: Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Family Handbook and Parent Service Organization content emphasize home-school alignment, parent partnership, and volunteering; GHNO invites parental formation and open visits. □filecite□turn7file15□turn7file5□
 - Time, Talent, Treasure: public materials describe a Community Investment campaign and PSO involvement; parents are encouraged to contribute and participate in campus life.
 - Public materials stress parent-teacher conferences, home-school alignment, and parent involvement as central to the classical education project.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords observed: partnership with families, parent formation, co-teachers, home-school community, parent involvement, PSO, open-campus, parent conferences, living tradition in the family. □filecite□turn7file4□turn7file15□
 - Negative keywords observed: minimal to no negative signals; the site depicts a highly engaged parent community, with no evident “customer” framing. (No explicit negative keywords appear in the site materials for this category.)
- Why this rating
 - GHNO’s public materials clearly present a strong, active partnership model with parents, extensive parent education/involvement, and open campus access. CLASSICAL.

Aggregate Ranking and Assessment

- Overall classification: CLASSICAL.
 - Five of six categories are CLASSICAL; Element 1 is assessed as SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL due to strong ideals of truth/goodness/beauty and virtue, but more explicit theology/liturgic signals are less clearly documented in the GHNO public materials.

What Would Move the Needle

- For a potential future needle-mover (if aiming to strengthen Element 1 further), GHNO could:
 - Make theology/theological formation and liturgical practices more explicit on the public site (e.g., clear statements about theology integration, liturgical year events, chapel/mass/worship cadence, and sacramental language where appropriate) while preserving the public-education, open-charter status.
 - Provide explicit statements connecting liturgical practices to daily classroom rhythms (to align with the liturgical practices vocabulary in the Six Elements lexicon) and reference to liturgical calendar integration in core curricula.
- No further major needle-moving changes are required to maintain GHNO’s CLASSICAL standing across the remaining categories, given the strong evidence of classical curriculum, pedagogy, faculty, and parental/community engagement.

ABSTRACT

Great Hearts Northern Oaks (GHNO) demonstrates a robust CLASSICAL orientation across most of the classical education rubric. The school centers formation and virtue within a liberal-arts framework, grounded in the pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty. Curriculum features include Seven Liberal Arts, Latin study, engagement with Great Books/Great Conversation, and a Western-tradition curriculum. Pedagogy combines Socratic dialogue, seminars, memory/recitation, and rhetoric-focused opportunities, with the lower-school program fostering memory and wonder. Public materials portray faculty as living mentors and a core culture, and parent/community life centers around partnership with families, PSO involvement, and ongoing home-school collaboration.

Category-by-category synthesis: - Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL. Evidence of transcendental ideals and virtue (truth/goodness/beauty) is strong, but explicit theology or liturgical practices are not robustly documented on the public site. - Purpose and Goal: CLASSICAL. Formation, wisdom, virtue, and liberal education are clearly articulated as the central aim. - Curriculum: CLASSICAL. Liberal arts foundation, Great Books/Great Conversation, Latin, and Western tradition are well evidenced. - Pedagogy: CLASSICAL. Socratic method, seminars, memory/recitation, and rhetoric are described; contemplative/restful elements are present but not dominant across all materials. - Faculty: CLASSICAL. Model-teacher/mentorship language and living-curriculum concepts are prominent. - Parents & Community: CLASSICAL. Strong parent-partnership, PSO, and family engagement are documented.

Overall assessment: CLASSICAL.

Cited evidence (selected): - Transcendentals, truth/goodness/beauty language and the formal pursuit of these ideals: GHNO public materials. [filecite\turn4file0\turn7file0](#) - Mission: “cultivate the minds and hearts of students through the pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty” and liberal-arts formation framing. [filecite\turn5file0\turn7file0](#) - Curriculum anchors: Latin study, Aristotle/Dostoyevsky, senior thesis; foundation in grammar, rhetoric, logic, history, natural science, philosophy. - Pedagogy signals: Socratic method, seminars, memory/recitation, and Atheneum programs. [filecite\turn7file0\turn6file7](#) - Faculty signals: Headmaster/Deans of Teachers/Academics; living curriculum language. - Parents/Community: Family Handbook, PSO, Time/Talent/Treasure, parent involvement. [filecite\turn7file4\turn5file15](#)

Note: The keyword analysis exercises drew on the Positive/Negative keyword indicators from the Six Essential Elements documents (e.g., [classicality_lexicon.v2.2.txt](#)), which provide the taxonomy for assessing each category (truth/goodness/beauty; formation; seven liberal arts; Socratic pedagogy; teacher as mentor; parental partnership; etc.). See documentation for the keyword lists and their intended signals. [filecite\turn7file9\turn3file1](#)

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY — CATEGORY-LEVEL SNAPSHOTS

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: transcendental framework; pursuit of truth/beauty/goodness; virtue; Socratic method shaping epistemology. [filecite\turn4file0\turn7file0\turn5file0](#)
 - Keywords: truth, goodness, beauty, transcendentals, virtue; limited theology/liturgy signals. Positive keyword count strong; minimal negative signals observed. CLASSIFICATION: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.
- Element 2: Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: formation-centered mission; liberal education framing; telos of truth/beauty/ goodness; contemplative/restful formation language.
 - Keywords: formation, liberal education, pursuing truth/goodness/beauty, contemplation. Minimal explicit workforce-readiness language. CLASSIFICATION: CLASSICAL.
- Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: grammar/logic/rhetoric; Latin; classical canon; Great Books; Western tradition; senior thesis; depth of study.
 - Keywords: Seven Liberal Arts; Great Books; Latin; Aristotle/Dostoyevsky; Western tradition. CLASSIFICATION: CLASSICAL.
- Element 4: Pedagogy — CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: Socratic discussions; seminars; rhetoric; memory/recitation; contemplative/restful aspects.
 - Keywords: Socratic method; seminars; rhetoric; memory/dictation; scholé. CLASSIFICATION: CLASSICAL.
- Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: living curriculum; model teachers; portrait of a teacher; leadership and professional development.
 - Keywords: model teachers; living curriculum; portrait of a teacher; faculty as friends. CLASSIFICATION: CLASSICAL.
- Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

-
- Evidence: strong parent partnership; PSO; family handbook; home-school alignment; community investment; open campus.
 - Keywords: partnership with families; parent formation; home-school collaboration; PSO; living tradition in the family. CLASSIFICATION: CLASSICAL.

If you'd like, I can extract verbatim quotes for each category's Evidence section or tailor the keyword tally to a stricter count from the exact lists in the Six Essential Elements documents.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

By reading or using this document, you acknowledge and accept the limitations described above.